

Graduation Requirements

Duration

- A PhD thesis **typically takes 3–4 years** to complete.

Credits

- To graduate, **30 ECTS** are required — see the **Curriculum**.
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Dissertation Format (Current AAU Regulations)

An article-based doctoral dissertation typically consists of **2–3 scientific articles**.

A licentiate dissertation must include **at least one article**.

In addition to what is outlined in this procedure, doctoral programmes may provide programme-specific guidelines for article-based dissertations.

The following are considered scientific articles:

- Published articles
- Articles accepted for publication
- Unpublished manuscripts that have undergone peer review or been accepted for publication
- Unpublished manuscripts submitted for peer review

Number of Articles

The articles constitute the main scientific contribution of the dissertation.

The number of articles depends on their **scope, scientific significance**, and **quality**, the **publication platform**, and the **author's individual contribution** in the case of co-authored articles.

At least **one article must be accepted for publication**.

In exceptional cases, the **Head of Department** may approve the submission of a dissertation with fewer articles than recommended, provided that the scope and quality are sufficiently high.

Preliminary examiners will pay particular attention to articles that have not yet been accepted for publication.

Doctoral Programme Recommendations

Within our doctoral programme, we **recommend** the following to emphasize **quality over quantity**:

- A **typical thesis consists of two high-quality papers**, with **at least one** paper as a **first-author** publication.
- **≥50%** of the included work should be **published** (or accepted).
- The decision to proceed to the **PhD defence** is made by the **supervisor** and the **head of subject**.

- For each manuscript included in the thesis, the **contribution of the PhD researcher must be clearly explained and justified**:
 - Avoid vague statements.
 - **List specific figure panels** and contributions (**data generation, analysis, etc.**)
 - Use a **template signed by the supervisor**.
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Full Regulations

-  **AAU PhD Regulations (PDF)**

Last updated: 15 November 2025